

TRUSTMRR · 1,000 STARTUPS · FROZEN 30 JUL 2026

Nobody is buying your product.

They're buying whoever they found first.

An investment thesis on 1,000 indie software businesses — and the one variable that separates the 21% that make money from the 59% that never will.

\$282

median MRR across the universe

0.18

correlation of followers to revenue

0.48

correlation of domain authority to revenue

\$133.8M of revenue — almost none of it where you'd look.

One thousand live, revenue-connected software businesses. The average tells you nothing — the median tells you everything.

1,000

businesses

with live payment-processor data

\$133.8M

trailing 12-mo revenue

across the full universe

\$282

median MRR

the typical business earns pocket money

59%

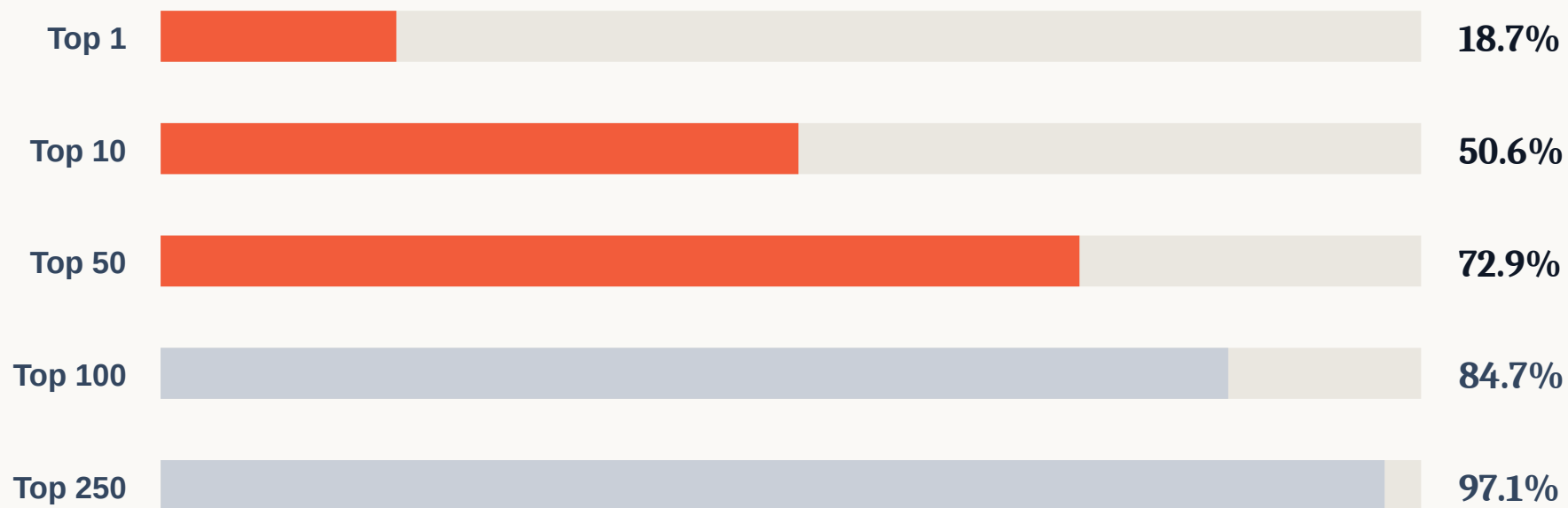
below \$1k MRR

not yet a business, at any valuation

The mean MRR is \$13,472. The median is \$282. Any thesis built on the average is a thesis about eleven outliers.

Ten companies own half the market.

Cumulative share of the \$133.8M in trailing 12-month revenue, ranked largest first.

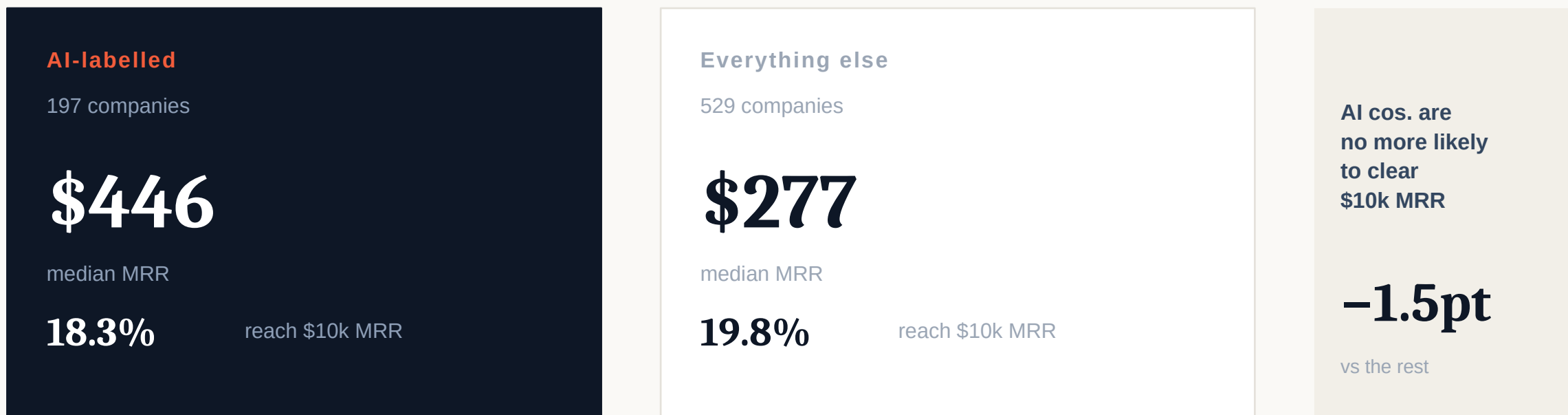


Investor read: the bottom 750 companies contribute under 3% of revenue. There is no index to buy here — only a selection problem.

■ MYTH 1

"AI" is a label, not a moat.

27% of all categorised businesses call themselves AI. It buys them almost nothing.

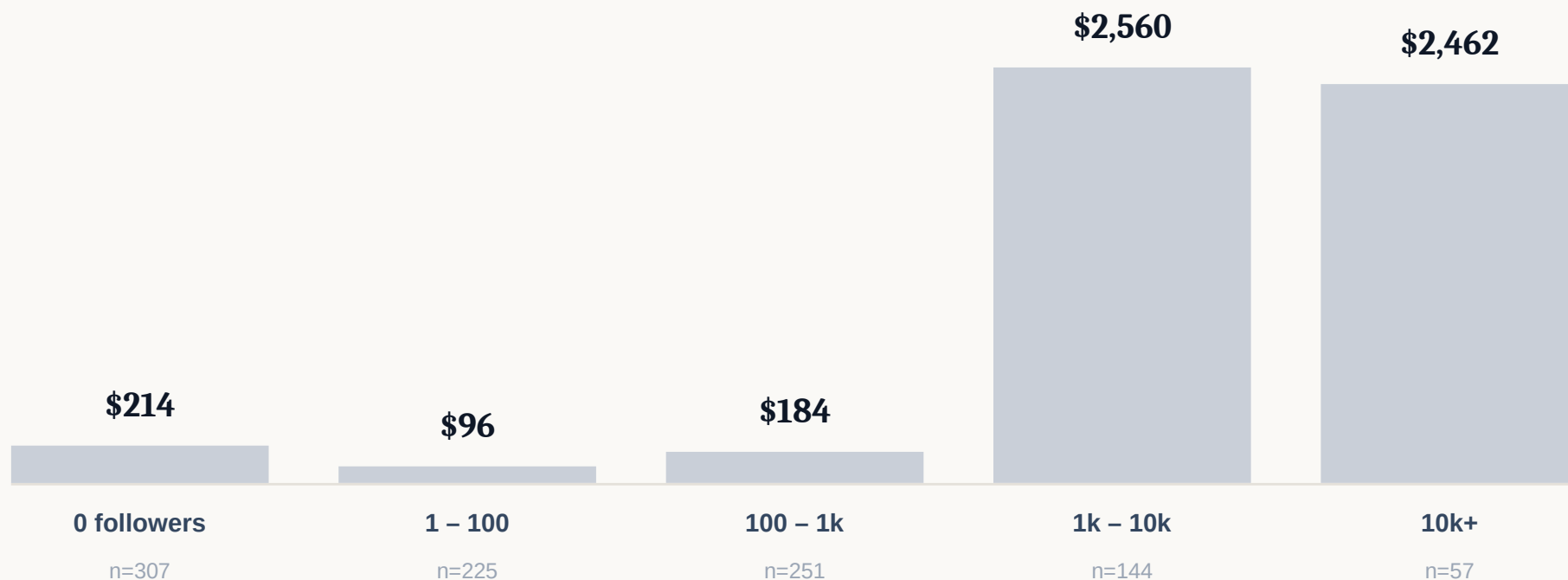


The AI label crowds the category without changing the outcome. Priced as a differentiator, it is a commodity.

n = 726 with a declared category · \$10k MRR hit-rate = share of cohort at or above \$10,000 MRR

The follower count is rented attention.

Median MRR by X (Twitter) following. The relationship is weak, and it isn't monotonic.



0.18

correlation
between followers
and MRR

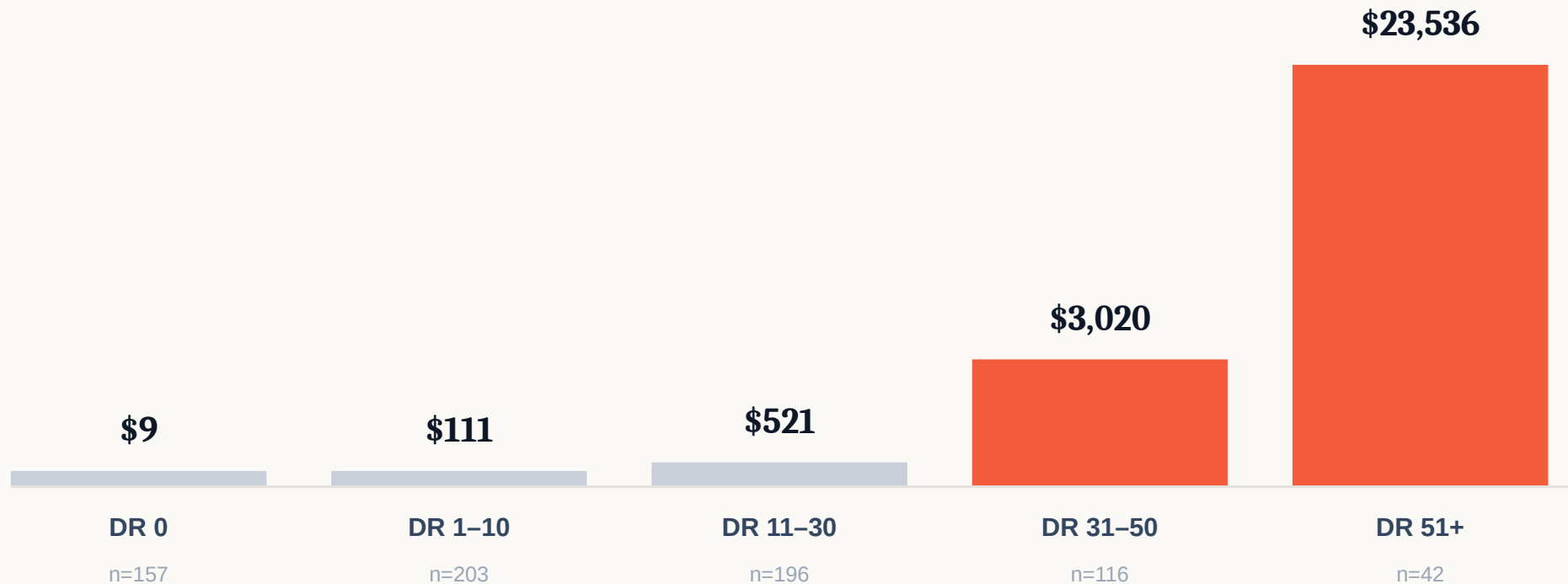
41%

of zero-follower
cos. still clear
\$1k MRR

Businesses with no audience at all out-earn those with a few hundred followers. Attention you rent does not compound.

One variable explains almost all of it.

Median MRR by Domain Rating — a measure of how much of the open web points back at you.



2,600×

median MRR gap
from bottom tier
to top tier

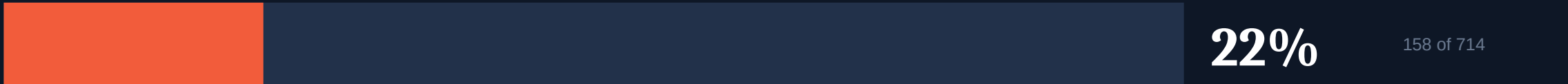
0.48

correlation with MRR
— 2.7× the strength of
follower count

Domain Rating is not a marketing metric here. It is the only proxy in this dataset for distribution the founder actually owns.

**22% of the companies.
81% of the money.**

Share of companies



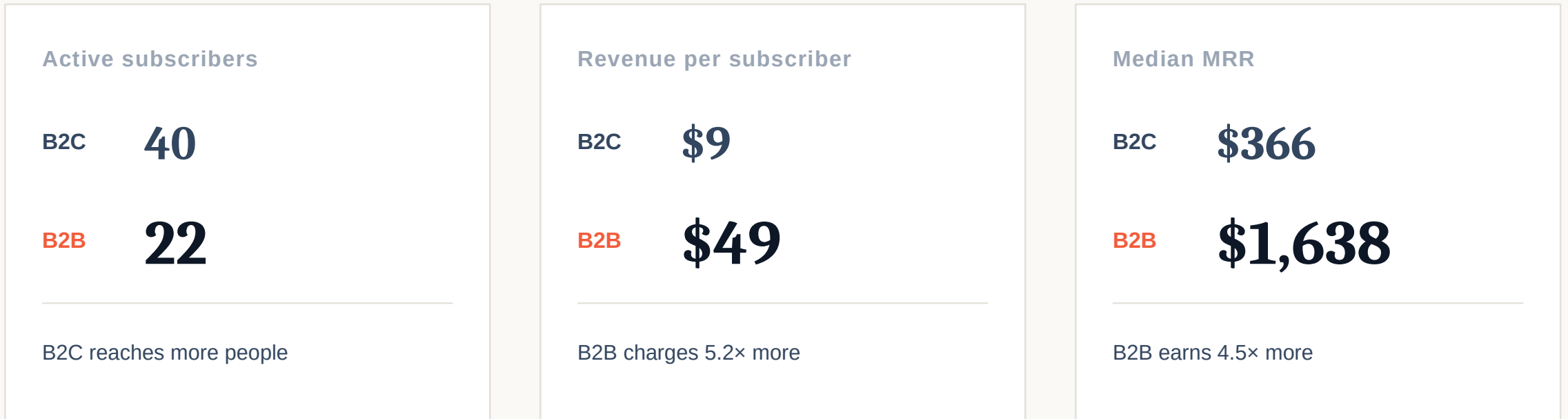
Share of revenue



Everything above Domain Rating 31 — one quarter of the universe — absorbs four fifths of every dollar earned.

B2C sells to more people for less money.

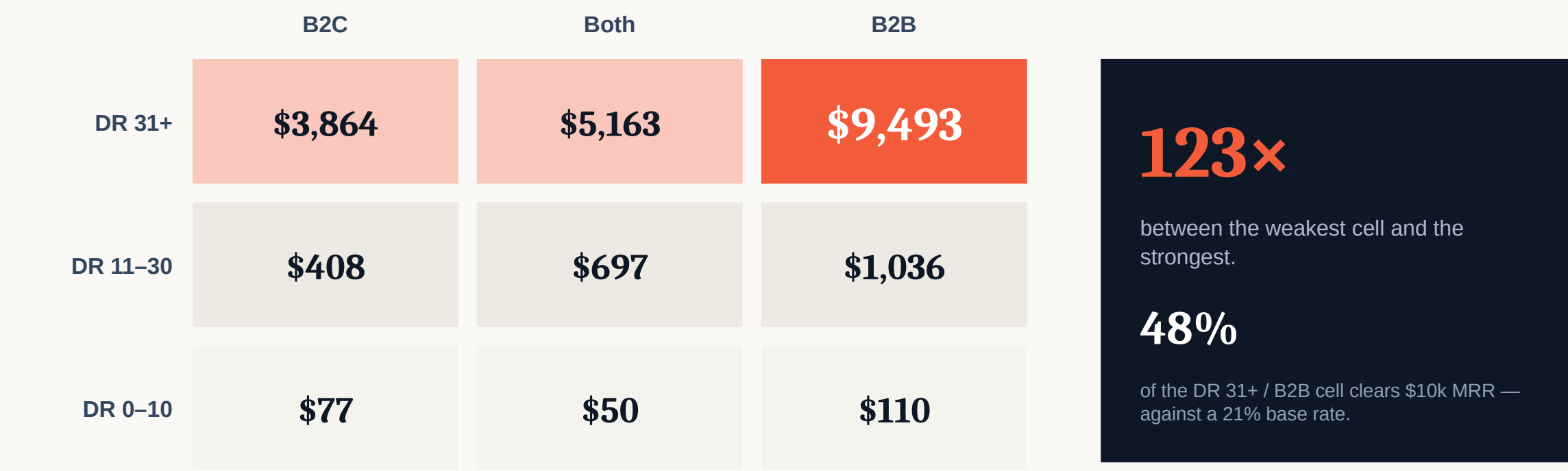
Median subscriber count, median revenue per subscriber, and median MRR — by audience.



B2B is 36% of the labelled universe and 70% of its revenue. Same effort, a customer worth five times as much.

The two levers multiply. They don't add.

Median MRR at each intersection of domain authority and audience.



Neither lever alone is enough. Authority without a business customer is a blog; a business customer without authority is a cold-email problem.

Two filters. 11% of the universe, 42% of the money.

A mechanical screen, applied to the same 1,000 rows — no judgement, no founder meetings.

1 Has a real domain

714 companies

Discard anything without owned web presence.

2 Domain Rating ≥ 31

158 companies

Keep only earned, compounding distribution.

3 Sells to businesses

81 companies

Keep only the audience that pays 5× more.

11%

of the screened universe

42%

of its total revenue

\$9,493

median MRR

48%

clear \$10k MRR (base: 21%)

And 262 of them are already for sale.

The dataset carries live asking prices — which means the thesis is testable with real capital, today.

262

businesses listed for sale

26% of the universe

\$35,000

median asking price

at 4.8× trailing revenue

\$1,055

median MRR of listed cos.

5.6× the unlisted median

LISTINGS THAT PASS THE SCREEN

15

companies currently on the market clear both filters.

\$150,000

median ask

3.2 yrs

payback at current MRR

A basket of fifteen, roughly \$2.2M all-in, buys ~\$700k of annualised recurring revenue attached to distribution that cannot be rebuilt quickly.

Buy distribution. The product is the cheap part.

01

Ignore the category.

AI, SaaS, mobile — the label moves the median by nothing. Category is how founders describe themselves, not how they earn.

02

Ignore the audience.

Follower count correlates 0.18 with revenue. Rented attention doesn't survive a platform's algorithm change.

03

Underwrite the domain.

Domain Rating correlates 0.48. The top tier earns 2,600× the bottom. It is slow to build, and therefore actually defensible.

What would break this

Revenue is self-reported and unaudited. Domain Rating is only measurable for 71% of the sample. And the causality could run backwards — successful companies can afford SEO. The rebuttal: the 262 live asking prices are a market willing to price this today, and the screen is cheap enough to test.